Mural

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"This is your name,"
a woman said,
then disappeared down a winding corridor.
I could see the sky within reach of my hands.
A white dove's wing carried me
toward another childhood. I had not dreamed
that I was dreaming. Everything was real.
I knew I was casting myself aside—
and flying. In the last orbit
I would become what I was to become.

And everything was white:
the sea suspended above the roof
of a white cloud, and nothingness itself
was white in the whiteness of the absolute sky.
I was, and I was not. Alone
in the far reaches of this white eternity,
I had arrived before my appointed time.
Not one angel appeared to ask:
"What did you do down there, in the world?"
I heard no hymns of the righteous,
no moaning of the damned.
Alone in the whiteness. Alone.

Nothing hurts me at the gate of resurrection:
not time, not feeling. I cannot sense
the lightness of things, or the weight of fear.
There was no one to ask:
Where has my where gone? Where is the city
of the dead? And where am I?
Here, in this nowhere, in this no-time,
there is neither nothingness nor being.
As though I had died before the present.
I know this vision. I know I am going
toward what I do not know. Perhaps
I am still alive somewhere,
and know what I desire.

One day I shall become what I desire.

One day I shall become an idea.
No sword will carry it into the wasteland,
no book. It will be like rain upon a mountain
split open by a blade of grass.
Neither force has triumphed,
nor justice in its exile.

One day I shall become what I desire.

One day I shall become a bird,
drawing my existence out of nothing.
Each time my wings catch fire
I come closer to the truth
and rise again from ash.
I am the conversation of dreamers.
I turned away from body and self
to finish my first journey toward meaning;
it scorched me, then vanished.
I am absence. I am the exile of heaven.

One day I shall become what I desire.

One day I shall become a vine.
Let summer press me into wine now;
let those passing by drink of me
beneath the chandeliers of this sweet place.
I am the message and its messenger,
the small addresses and the post.

One day I shall become what I desire.

"This is your name,"
a woman said,
and vanished down a corridor of white.
This is your name. Remember it well.
Do not quarrel with a single letter.
Pay no mind to the banners of tribes.
Befriend your name, stretched toward the horizon.
Try it among the living and the dead;
teach it its proper sound among strangers.
Carve it on a stone inside a cave.
O my name, you will grow as I grow;
you will carry me, and I will carry you.

A stranger is a stranger's brother.
We shall take the feminine with a vowel
set aside for the flutes.
O my name, where are we now?
Tell me: what is now? What is tomorrow?
What is time, and what is place?
What is old, and what is new?

One day we shall become what we desire.

The journey has not started;
the road has not ended.
The wise have not yet reached their estrangement,
nor have strangers reached their wisdom.
We knew no flowers but wild anemones.
Let us climb to the highest murals.
The earth of my poem is green, and high;
at dawn, God's word is the earth of my poem.
And I am far away.
I am far away.

In every wind, a woman troubles her poet:
"Take back the direction you gave me,
the direction that broke.
Give me back my womanhood.
I have nothing left but watching
the creases on the lake.
Take tomorrow away from me;
bring back yesterday. Leave us together.
After you, nothing will depart
or return."

"And take the poem, if you wish;
there is no one in it but you.
Take your 'I.' I shall complete my exile
with the letters your hands left for the doves."
Which of us is the 'I'
who must be the last of us?
A star will fall between writing and speech,
and memory will unfold its thoughts:

We were born in the age of sword and flute,
between the fig and the cactus.
Death was slower then. More visible.
It was a truce among travelers
at the river mouth. Now an electronic button
works on its own. No killer listens
to those he kills; no martyr
reads out his last testament.

"From which wind have you come?
Tell me the name of your wound,
so I can recognize the roads
on which we shall be lost twice."
Every beat of my heart in you hurts me
and brings me back to a mythic age.
My blood hurts. Salt hurts.
Even the vein itself hurts.

In a broken jar the women of the Syrian coast
wept for the distance they had traveled,
and burned beneath the August sun.
I saw them on the path to the spring
before I was born. I heard the water
crying for them inside the clay:
"Go back to the cloud;
let the abundant age return."

The echo said:
"Nothing returns but the past of the powerful,
engraved on the obelisks of time.
Their monuments are golden;
golden, too, are the letters
of the weak to tomorrow:
Give us enough bread to live on,
and a present stronger than this.
For we have no rebirth, no indwelling,
no eternity."

The echo said:
"I am weary of my incurable hope,
weary of the snares of beauty.
What comes after Babylon?
Every time the road toward heaven clears,
and the unknown reveals my final goal,
prose spreads through the prayers
and the song breaks."

Green—the earth of my poem is green and high.
It looks down on me from the plain of my abyss.
You are a stranger inside your own meaning.
It is enough to be there, alone,
to become a whole tribe.
I sang to measure the wasted distances
in the pain of a dove,
not to explain what God says to humankind.
I am no prophet claiming revelation,
proclaiming that ascent is my abyss.

And I am the stranger, with all the language
I have been given. If I could tame feeling
with the Arabic letter dad,
feeling would master me with the letter ya.
Words, when distant, possess a country
beside a higher planet; when near,
they are an exile. A book is not enough
to let me say: I found myself fully present
in the heart of absence.

Whenever I searched for myself,
I found other people. Whenever I searched
for them, I found only my strange self.
Am I one person, or a crowd?

I am the stranger. I am tired of the Milky Way
to the beloved, tired of my own description.
Form narrows. Language expands.
I overflow the needs of a single word.
I look at myself in mirrors:
Is that me? Have I played my part well
in the final act? Did I read the play
before this performance, or was it forced on me?
Am I the one playing the part,
or did the victim change her lines
to survive postmodernity, after the author
strayed from the script
and the actors and witnesses went away?

I sat behind the door, watching:
Is that me?
This is my language. This voice
is the prick of blood in my veins.
But the author is someone else.
I am not myself if I arrive but never reach.
I am not myself if I speak but say nothing.
I am the one to whom the mysterious letters say:

Write, and you will be.
Read, and you will find.
And when you wish to speak, act;
your opposites will meet in meaning.
Your transparent inner life is the poem.

Sailors surround me, but there is no harbor.
Emptiness has emptied me of sign and speech.
I found no time to discover my brief station
between two stations. I have yet to ask
what it means that two doors look so alike:
is one an exit, or an entrance?

I found no death to seize life from,
no voice to cry out:
"O racing time! You have snatched me
away from what the mysterious letters say:
Reality is imagination made certain."

O time that would not wait,
that never waited for anyone late to be born:
make the past new again. It is the only memory
we share, from the days when we were your friends,
not victims of your speeding carriages.
Leave the past as it is:
it neither follows nor leads.

I saw what the dead remember,
and what they forget.
They do not grow old. They read the hours
on their wristwatches. They know nothing
of our deaths, or even of their own lives.
Nothing remains of what I was or will be.
All the pronouns come undone:
he inside I, I inside you.
No whole, no part; no living voice
says to a dead one, "Be yourself!"
Elements and feelings fall apart.
I cannot see my body there,
or feel death's violence,
or the surge of my first life.
I am no longer my own self.
Who am I—the one lost, or the newborn?

Time is zero. I had not thought of birth
when death flew me toward the nebula.
I was neither alive nor dead;
there was no nothingness there, and no being.
My nurse said, “You are doing better,”
and injected the anesthetic.
“Be calm. Be worthy of the dreams
that are about to come.”

I saw my French doctor open my cell
and strike me with a stick,
helped by two suburban policemen.
I saw my father returning from the pilgrimage,
unconscious from a Hijazi sunstroke,
saying to the angels around him:
“Put me out!”

I saw young men from Morocco
playing football, throwing stones at me:
“Go back on the ferry!
Leave us our mother,
you father who went to the wrong grave!”

I saw René Char sitting with Heidegger
two meters away from me.
They drank wine and did not look for poetry.
Their conversation was a beam of light;
a passing tomorrow waited.

I saw my three companions weeping
as they stitched a shroud for me
with threads of gold.

I saw al-Ma'arri drive the critics
out of his poem:
“I am not blind so I can see what you see.
Insight is a light that leads
to nothingness—or madness.”

I saw a country embrace me
with morning hands:
“Be worthy of the smell of bread,
worthy of the flowers at the curb.
Your mother’s oven is still burning,
and her greeting is warm as a loaf.”

Green is the earth of my poem, green.
One river is enough for me to whisper
to the butterfly, “Ah, my sister.”
One river is enough to tempt old myths
to survive on the falcon’s wing
as it changes banners and distant peaks,
where armies built for me
kingdoms of oblivion.

No people is smaller than its poem.
Yet weapons widen words
for its living and its dead.
Letters polish the sword
hanging from the belt of dawn,
and the desert grows or shrinks with songs.

No lifetime is long enough
to fasten my ending to my beginning.
Shepherds took my story and pressed on
through the grass above the ruins' charms.
With trumpets and familiar rhymes
they defeated forgetting,
leaving me the hoarseness of memory
on the stone of farewell. They did not return.

Our days were pastoral, between tribe and city.
I found no private night for your litter
crowned with mirage. You said to me:
“What use is my name without you?
Call me. You made me when you named me;
you killed me when you owned the name.”

“How did I kill you?”
“I am a stranger in all this night.
Bring me into the forest of your desire.
Hold me and press me; pour the pure honey
of our wedding over the hive.
Scatter me with all the winds in your hands,
then gather me. Night gives its soul to you,
stranger. Not a star will see me
without knowing my family will kill me
with the waters of lapis lazuli.
So take me, so that as I break my jar
with my own hands, I may have
a happy present.”

“Did I tell you anything to change your road?”
“No.”
My life was outside me.

I am the one who talks to himself:
My last ode has fallen from my palms.
I am the traveler inside myself,
besieged by opposites. Yet life deserves
its mystery, and its sparrow.
I was not born to know I would die,
but to love what is held in God’s shadow.
Beauty leads me toward the beautiful.
I love your love, free from self and attributes.
And I am my own substitute.

I am the one who talks to himself:
From the smallest things the greatest ideas arise.
Rhythm does not come from words,
but from two bodies becoming one
through a long night.

I am the one who talks to himself
and tames memory:
Are you me?
A third presence flutters between us,
a perpetual forget-me-not.
O death of ours, take us in your own way;
perhaps we will learn to shine.

No sun, no moon above me.
I left my shadow tangled
in a thornbush. The place grew light
and my wandering soul carried me away.

I am the one who talks to himself:
“Daughter, what have your longings done to you?
The wind burnishes us and bears us off
like the scent of autumn. You have ripened,
my woman, against my walking stick.
Now you may take the road to Damascus,
trusting what you see. A guardian angel
and two doves flutter over the life
we have left. The earth is a festival.”

The earth is a festival for the defeated,
and we are among them.
We are those who preferred an epic song
to a settled place. Our tents in the wind
were like the feathers of an old eagle.
We were gentle and unworldly,
though we had no teachings of Christ.
We were no stronger than grass
except at summer's end.

You are my truth; I am your question.
We inherited nothing but our two names.
You are my garden; I am your shadows
at the crossroads of the epic song.
We played no part in the schemes
of the goddesses who began the hymn
with sorcery and cunning, bearing place
upon the horns of an ibex
from one age to another.

We would have been natural people
had the stars in our sky been a little higher
than the stones of our well,
and the prophets a little less insistent.
The soldiers never heard our praise.

Green—the earth of my poem is green.
Singers carry it from my time to my time,
intact in all its fertility.
From it I have Narcissus studying his face
in the water; from it, the clarity
of shadows among synonyms,
and the precision of meaning.

From it I have the resemblance
between the prophets' suffering
on the rooftops of night.
From it, the forgotten donkey of wisdom
on the hill, laughing at its myth and reality.
And from it, a symbol swollen with opposites:
neither embodiment can return it from memory,
nor abstraction raise it
toward the great illumination.

And from it, another self, writing her days
in the notebooks of singers:
“If this dream is not enough,
I have a heroic vigil at exile’s gate.”
From it, too, the echo of my language
upon the walls, scraping away its sea salt
whenever a stubborn heart betrays me.

My wisdom rose higher than the valleys
when I told the devil:
“No. Do not test me.
Do not trap me in opposing choices.
Leave me as I am, indifferent
to the tale of the Old Testament,
ascending toward heaven. My kingdom is there.
Take history, son of my father—take history;
do with your instincts what you will.
I will keep the stillness.”

A small grain of wheat will be enough
for me and my brother, the enemy.
My hour has not yet come.
The harvest is not ready.
I must enter absence, first believe
my heart, then follow it
to Cana of Galilee.
My hour has not yet come.

Perhaps something inside me disowns me.
Perhaps I am someone else.
The fig trees have not yet ripened
around the girls’ dresses.
The phoenix’s feather has not given me birth.
No one is waiting there for me.
I arrived too early and too late;
no one would believe what I had seen.
I am the one who saw.
And I am far away. Far away.

Who are you, my other self?
On the road we are two;
at resurrection, one.
Lead me toward the light of vanishing
so I may see what I become
in my other image.
After you, my other self, who will I be?
My body—

behind me, or ahead of you?
Who am I, you who are me?
Make me as I have made you.
Anoint me with almond oil;
crown me with cedar.
Carry me from the valley
to a white eternity. Teach me life
in your own way. Test me as a speck
in the world above. Help me bear
the boredom of forever. Be gentle
when you wound me and roses
rise from my veins.

Our hour has not come.
There are no messengers measuring time
by the last fistful of grass. Has it turned?
No angels come to visit the place
so poets may leave their past
upon a beautiful twilight
and open tomorrow with their own hands.

Sing, my chosen goddess, O Anat,
my first poem of creation once again.
Perhaps storytellers will find
a willow's birth certificate
in an autumn stone. Perhaps shepherds
will find a well at the bottom of a song.
Perhaps life will come without warning
to those who have renounced meaning,
on a butterfly's wing caught in a rhyme.
Sing, my chosen goddess, Anat.
I am both quarry and arrows,
I am speech.
I am the eulogist, the caller to prayer,
and the martyr.

I never said farewell to the ruins,
for I was never what I was
except once. Once was enough
to know how time breaks
like a Bedouin tent in the north wind,
how place splits open and the past
wears the dust of an abandoned temple.
Everything around me resembles me,
yet I resemble nothing here.

As though the earth were too narrow
for lyric souls, the poor mad children
of devils who, whenever they glimpse
a beautiful dream, teach a parrot
poems of love and see borders
open before them.

I want to live. I have work to do
aboard the ship: not to save a bird
from our hunger or the dizziness of the sea,
but to watch the flood from near at hand.
What follows it? What will those who survive
do with the ancient earth? Will they tell
the story again? Where does it begin,
and where does it end?
None of the dead has returned
to tell us the truth.

O Death, wait for me outside the earth.
Wait in your country until I finish
a passing conversation with what remains
of my life beside your tent. Wait
until I have finished reading Tarafa ibn al-Abd.
The existentialists tempt me
to use up every fleeting moment:
freedom, justice, the wine of gods.

O Death, wait until I arrange my funeral
in the tender spring where I was born,
where I will forbid the speakers
to repeat their speeches about a sad country
and the endurance of figs and olives
against time and its armies.

I will say: pour me into the letter nun,
where my spirit drank its fill
of the Qur'an's sura of the Merciful.
Walk silently with me
to the footsteps of my ancestors
and the reed flute in my eternity.
Do not lay violets on my grave:
they are the flowers of the disappointed,
reminding the dead that love died too young.
Lay seven green ears of wheat
upon my coffin, if you find them,
and some wild anemones, if you can.
Otherwise leave the roses of churches
to churches and brides.

Death, wait until I have packed my bag:
toothbrush, soap, razor, cologne,
clothes. Is the weather mild there?
Do the seasons change in white eternity,
or does it remain the same
through autumn and winter?
Will one book be enough to amuse me
in a place without time, or will I need
a library? What language do they speak:
one common to everybody,
or classical Arabic?

Death, wait. O Death, wait
until spring gives me back my clarity
and my health. Be an honorable hunter
who does not shoot a gazelle at the spring.
Let us be frank, even friendly:
what is yours of my life is yours
when I have filled it; what is mine of you
is contemplation of the stars.
No one dies entirely. Souls merely change
their shapes and the places where they live.

Death, my shadow that will guide me,
third among two, color trembling
in emerald and chrysolite,
peacock's blood, hunter of the wolf's heart,
sickness of imagination:
sit in the chair. Lay your hunting tools
beneath my window, hang your heavy ring
of keys above the door.

Do not stare into my arteries,
powerful one, searching out
the last weak spot. You are stronger
than the medical establishment,
stronger than my breathing machine,
stronger than the might of honey.
You do not need my illness to kill me.
Rise above the insects. Be yourself:
transparent, cool, the clear face of the unseen.
Be like love, a storm among trees.
Do not sit on thresholds like a beggar
or a tax collector. Do not be a traffic cop.
Be strong, bright as steel;
throw away your fox masks.
Be chivalrous, beautiful, precise in every blow.

Say what you like:
"I move from meaning to meaning.
Life is fluid, and I give it density;
I define it by my power and my measure."

Death, wait. Sit here in the chair,
have a glass of wine. Do not bargain.
One like you bargains with no one;
one like me does not defy
the servant of the unknown.
Rest. Perhaps the war of the stars
has tired you today.
Why would you visit someone like me?
Do you have time to examine my poem?
No. That is not your concern.
You are responsible for what is clay
in the human being, not for what we do or say.

All the arts have defeated you, Death.
The songs of Mesopotamia defeated you.
The Egyptian obelisk, the pharaohs' tombs,
the carvings on my temple stones:
they defeated you, escaped your ambush,
and won a kind of immortality.
Do with us, and with yourself, what you will.

But I want—I want to live.
I have work to do on the geography
of the volcano. From Lot's days
to the resurrection of Hiroshima,
wasteland remains wasteland.
As though I had always lived here,
I hunger for what I do not know.
Perhaps now is farther off,
yesterday nearer, tomorrow already past.
Yet I hold the present tighter by the hand
so history, not endlessly circling time,
may pass beside me like the unruly leap
of mountain goats.

Will I escape tomorrow
the speed of electronic time,
or the slow passage of my caravan
through the desert? I have work to do
for my afterlife, as though I will not live
tomorrow, and work for my day,
my ever-present day. So I listen, slowly,
very slowly, to the ants inside my heart:

"Help me bear my skin."
I hear the captive stone cry:
"Set my body free."
In the violin I see longing emigrating
from my country of dust
to my country of sky.

I hold, in a woman's hand,
my familiar eternity: I was created,
then I loved, then I died, then woke
in the grass upon my grave
pointing toward me from time to time.
What use is gentle spring
if it cannot comfort the dead,
then carry on life's delight after them,
and the freshness of forgetting?
This is one way to solve the mystery of poetry—
of my love poetry, at least.
And dreams are our only road to speech.

Death, disguise yourself. Sit down
upon the crystal of my days
as though you were one of my oldest friends,
an exile among living things.
You alone are exiled.
You have no life of your own:
your life is nothing but my death.
You neither live nor die.
You snatch infants from their thirst
for milk back into milk.
You were never a child for whom
finches rocked a cradle,
nor did small angels or the antlers
of an absent-minded deer caress you,
as they caressed us, guests of the butterfly.

You alone are exiled, poor soul.
No woman holds you to her breast;
no woman shares with you the longing
that makes night economical in its words,
its unashamed language where earth
and heaven mingle inside us.
No child of yours has ever come to plead:
"Father, I love you."

You alone are exiled, king of kings.
No praise attends your scepter,
no falcons perch upon your horse,

no pearls surround your crown.
You, naked of flags and sacred trumpet,
why do you walk without guards,
without a chorus singing your glory,
like a timid thief? Yet you are
who you are: the exalted sovereign
of the dead, the strong one,
commander of the stubborn Assyrian army.

Do with us and with yourself what you will.
I want to live, and forget you.
Forget our long acquaintance.
Not for any grand reason;
only to read the letters
written by the distant heavens.
Whenever I prepare to wait for you,
you draw farther away.
Whenever I say, "Leave me alone
until I finish the turning of two bodies
inside my overflowing body,"
you appear between me and myself, mocking:
"Do not forget our appointment."

"When?"
"At the height of forgetfulness,
when you believe in this world
and kneel before the wooden idols
and the drawings on a cave wall, saying:
These are my traces. I am my own son."

"Where shall we meet? May I choose
a café by the gate of the sea?"
"No. Do not approach, son of sin,
son of Adam, the limits set by God.
You were not born to ask questions,
but to work."

"Be a good friend, Death.
Become a cultural meaning
so I may understand your hidden wisdom.
Perhaps you taught Cain to shoot too soon,
and Job to be patient too late.
Perhaps you saddled me a horse
to kill me on my own horse.
As though—

when I remember forgetting,
my language rescues the present.
As though I were always present,
always a bird. As though, since I met you,
my language had become addicted
to its fragility on your white carriages,
higher than the clouds of sleep,
higher still when feeling breaks free
of the burden of all the elements.

You and I are Sufis on God's road,
condemned to visions we cannot see.
Return alone, Death, safely home.
I am free here in this nowhere,
in this not-there. Go back to your exile;
go back to your hunting tools.
Wait for me at the gate of the sea.
Prepare a red wine to celebrate
my return from visiting the sick earth.

Do not be harsh or hard of heart.
I will not come to laugh at you,
or walk upon the lake
in the north of the soul.
But, having let you tempt me,
I have neglected the poem's ending:
I did not bring my mother to my father
on my horse. I left the gate open
for the singers' Andalusia,
and stood instead upon the fence
of almond and pomegranate,
brushing cobwebs from the cloak
of my noble grandfather.

A foreign army was crossing
those same old roads, measuring
time with the same old engines of war.
Death, is this history—your twin,
or your enemy—climbing
between two abysses?
Perhaps a dove will build her nest
and lay eggs inside an iron helmet.
Perhaps wormwood will grow
through the wheels of a wrecked car.
What will history, your twin or enemy,
do to nature when earth marries heaven
and sheds its sacred rain?

Death, wait for me at the sea gate,
in the romantics' café.
I came back, after your arrows missed,
only to lay my inner life outside me,
to scatter the wheat filling my soul
for the blackbird perched on my hands
and shoulders, and to say goodbye
to the earth that absorbs me as salt,
then scatters me as grass
for the horse and the gazelle.

Wait until I finish my short visit
to time and place. Do not believe me
when I say I will return—or will not.
I say thank you to life,
though I was neither living nor dead.
And you alone were alone,
O lonely one.

My nurse says:
"You were delirious for so long.
You kept crying: Heart! My heart!
Take me to the bathroom!"

What is the soul worth
if my body is sick and cannot perform
its first and simplest duty?
Heart, my heart, return my steps to me,
let me walk to the bathroom by myself.
I have forgotten my arms, my legs,
my knees, and gravity's apple.
Forgotten what my heart is for,
Eve's garden at the dawn of eternity,
forgotten my little organ,
forgotten how to breathe with my lungs.
Forgotten speech.
I fear for my language.
Leave everything exactly as it was,
but give my language life again.

My nurse says:
"You were delirious. You shouted:
I do not want to return to anyone.
I do not want to go back to any country
after this long absence.
I want only to return to my language,
out beyond the farthest cooing of doves."

My nurse says:
"You were delirious for so long.
You asked whether death was
what I was doing to you,
or whether it was the death of language."

Green—the earth of my poem is green, and high.
Slowly I write it, slowly,
to the measure of gulls in the book of water.
I write it and leave it to those who ask:
"For whom do we sing
when salt has spread through the dew?"

Green. I write it in scattered ears of wheat
upon the field's open book,
its arch pale and full,
within it and within me.
Whenever I befriend an ear of wheat,
or call it brother, I learn how to live
from death and its opposite:
"I am the grain of wheat that died
to turn green once more.
In my dying, there is a kind of life."

As though I were not as I am.
No one died there in my place.
What words can the dead remember
except gratitude: God have mercy on us.
I am comforted by remembering
what rhetoric made me forget:
I did not father a child
to carry his father's death.
I preferred a free marriage among words.
The feminine will find a suitable masculine
when poetry leans toward prose.

My limbs will grow gray upon a sycamore.
My heart will pour its earthly water
into one of the planets.
Who am I in the death that follows me?
Who am I in the death before me?

A shadow at the edge said:
“Osiris was like you, like me.
Mary’s son was like you, like me.
But a wound at just the right moment
hurts sick nothingness,
and raises temporary death
to an idea.”

Where does poetry come from?
From the intelligence of the heart,
or the instinct that senses the unknown?
From a red rose in the desert?
Nothing personal is truly personal,
nothing universal truly universal.
As though I were not as I am.

Each time I listened to my heart
I filled with what the unseen was saying,
and the trees lifted me.
From dream to dream I fly
with no final destination.
I have been being born for thousands of years
of poetry, in my linen-white darkness.
I never knew exactly which of us was me,
and which was my dream.
I am my dream.
As though I were not as I am.

My language would not leave behind
its shepherd’s accent except
on a journey north. Our dogs grew quiet.
Our goats wrapped themselves in mist
upon the hills. A stray arrow
split certainty’s face.
I grew weary of a language
that both speaks and does not speak
from horseback of what the past
has done to the days of Imru' al-Qays,
torn between a rhyme and an emperor.

Each time I turned my face
toward my gods in the land of purple,
a moon encircled by Anat shone upon me,
Anat, mistress of metaphor in the story.
She wept for no one, but she wept
from her own enchantment:

“Is all this magic meant for me alone?
Is there no poet at my side
to share the empty throne of my glory,
to gather what overflows
of roses from the fence of my womanhood?
No poet to tempt the milk of night
within my breasts?
I am the first. I am the other.
My solitude has exceeded its bounds.
After me gazelles run through the words.
There is no before me, and no after.”

I shall dream—not to mend
the carriages of the wind,
or repair a wound in the soul.
Myth has taken its place,
its cunning place, in the real.
A poem cannot change a past
that passes and will not pass,
nor stop an earthquake.
Still I shall dream.

Perhaps a country will have room for me,
just as I am: one of the people of this sea,
who has stopped asking the hard question,
“Who am I, here? Am I my mother’s son?”
Doubt will not trouble me;
neither shepherds nor kings will besiege me.
My present, like my future, is mine.

I carry my little notebook.
Whenever a bird brushes against a cloud,
I write: The dream has set my wings free.
I, too, can fly. Every living thing is a bird.
And I am I, and nothing else.

One of the people of this plain.
At the barley festival I visit my ruins,
beautiful as a tattoo of identity
that the winds cannot erase
and cannot make eternal.
At the festival of vines I drink a cup
of the peddlers’ wine. My soul is light;
my body is heavy with memory and place.

In spring I become a thought
in the mind of a traveler
who writes on a postcard:
“To the left of the abandoned theater,
an iris and a mysterious figure.
To the right, a modern city.”
And I am I, and nothing else.

I am not among Rome’s followers
keeping watch over the roads of salt.
Still I am forced to pay a percentage
of my bread’s salt. I tell history:
Decorate your trucks with slaves
and humbled kings, and pass on.
No one says no anymore.
And I am I, and nothing else.

One of the people of this night.
I dream of mounting my horse,
higher and higher, following the spring
behind the hill. Hold steady, my horse.
We are no longer divided in the wind.
You are my youth; I am your shadow.
Stand upright as an alif, strike lightning.
With the hoof of desire scrape
at the vessels of echo.
Climb, renew yourself, stand like an alif,
taut as a bow, my horse. Do not tumble
down the last slope like an abandoned flag
in the alphabet.

We are no longer divided in the wind.
You are my cause; I am your metaphor,
beyond the procession tamed like fate.
Charge forward. Carve out my time—

in my own place, my horse.
Place is the road, and there is no road
upon the road but you, shod in wind.
Light stars in the mirage,
light clouds in absence.
Be my brother and the guide of my lightning,
my horse. Do not die before me,
after me, or beside me
on the final slope.
Look at the ambulance, and the dead.
Perhaps I am still alive.

I shall dream—not to mend
some external meaning,
but to restore the abandoned rooms
inside me, ruined by emotional drought.
I know my heart by heart.
It is no longer spoiled or meddlesome;
an aspirin is enough to soften it.
It is like a neighbor I barely know,
and I am no longer subject
to its whims or its women.
The heart can rust like iron,
no longer aching, longing, or running wild
at the first intimate rain,
no longer singing like August grass
dried to a crisp.
As though my heart were an ascetic,
or something extra, like the letter kaf
in an unnecessary comparison.
When the heart's water dries,
aesthetics grow more abstract;
feelings wrap themselves in coats,
and innocence dresses as skill.

Each time I turned my face
toward the earliest songs,
I saw the sandgrouse's tracks in speech.
I was not a happy child,
so I cannot say yesterday
was always more beautiful.
Yet memory has two light hands
that raise a fever in the earth.
Memory has the scent of a night flower
that weeps and wakes in exile's blood
the need to sing:
"Become the height of my sorrow,
and I shall find my time."

All I need is the beat of a gull's wing
to follow the old ships.
How much time has passed
since we discovered the twins:
time, and natural death,
life's other name?
Still we live as though death
might somehow miss us.
We who can remember
can also be free, following

the green footsteps of Gilgamesh
from my age to my age.

The void of perfect creation.
Absence breaks me like a little water jar.
Enkidu slept and did not wake.
My wing slept, folded around
a handful of its clay-colored feathers.
My gods are the stillness of wind
in the land of imagination.
My right arm is a wooden staff;
my heart a deserted well, emptied of water,
where the savage echo grows:

"Enkidu! Imagination is no longer enough
to complete my journey.
I need strength to make my dream real.
Bring me my weapons;
I will polish them with the salt of tears.
Bring me tears, Enkidu,
so the dead within us may mourn the living.
What am I? Who sleeps now, Enkidu—
you, or I? My gods are like
trying to seize the wind.

Rise with me in all your human recklessness.
Dream of a little equality
between the gods of heaven and ourselves,
we who build the beautiful land
between the Tigris and Euphrates
and remember its names.
How could you tire of me, my friend,
and abandon me? What use is wisdom
without the fire of youth?
What use is our wisdom?

At the door of the labyrinth
you abandoned me, my friend;
you killed me. Alone I must look,
alone, upon our destinies.
Alone I bear the world on my shoulders
like a raging bull. Alone I wander
searching for my eternity.
I must solve this riddle, Enkidu.
I shall carry your years as far as I can,
as far as my strength and will
can carry you. But who am I alone?
The void of perfect creation is all around.

I will lean your naked shadow
against the palm trees. But where is it?
Where is your shadow, now your trunks
are broken? The summit of humanity
is an abyss.
I wronged you when I fought the beast
inside you with a woman
who gave you her milk. You grew tame,
surrendered to being human.
Enkidu, be gentle with me.
Return from where you died.
Perhaps together we can find the answer.
Who am I alone? One life is incomplete.
I am missing even the question.
Whom shall I ask about crossing the river?

Rise, brother of salt, and carry me.
As you sleep, do you know you sleep?
Wake! Enough sleep. Move
before the sages multiply around me
like foxes, saying:

"Everything is vanity. Take your life
as it is, a moment pregnant with its juices,
the distilled blood of grass.
Live for today, not for your dream.
Everything passes. Beware tomorrow.
Live now in the embrace of a woman
who loves you. Live for your body,
not your illusions. Wait for a son
to carry your spirit into the world.
Immortality is the renewal of life
through birth. Everything is vanity,
passing, passing or vain."

Who am I?
The Song of Songs, or Ecclesiastes?
Both of them are me.
I am a poet, a king, and a sage
on the edge of a well.
No cloud rests in my hand,
no eleven stars shine over my temple.
My body has grown too small for me;
my eternity too small.
And tomorrow sits like a crown of dust
upon my chair.

Vanity, vanity of vanities—vanity.
All things on earth pass away.
The wind blows north;
the wind blows south.
The sun rises out of itself,
and sets into itself.
There is nothing new.
Time was yesterday,
weaving the same thread again.

The temples rise high,
the ears of wheat rise high.
When the sky stoops, it rains;
when countries rise too far, they turn barren.
Everything that exceeds its measure
will one day become its opposite.
Life upon the earth is the shadow
of what we cannot see.

Vanity, vanity of vanities—vanity.
All things on earth pass away.

A chariot and twelve thousand horses
carry my name, written in gold,
from one age to another.
I have lived as no poet lived,
a king and a sage.
I have grown old, grown tired of glory.
Nothing is lacking.
Is that why, the more I know,
the greater my sorrow?

What are Jerusalem and the throne?
Nothing stays as it is.
A time to be born,
a time to die,
a time to be silent,
a time to speak,
a time for war,
a time for peace,
a time for time itself.
Nothing stays as it is.

Every river ends in the sea,
but the sea is never full.
Nothing stays as it is.
Every living thing moves toward death,
but death is never full.

Nothing will remain of me
except my name written in gold:
“Solomon was here.”
What will my dead do with their names?
Will the gold illuminate
my enormous darkness?
Or will it be the Song of Songs,
and Ecclesiastes?

Vanity, vanity of vanities—vanity.
All things on earth pass away.

As Christ walked upon the lake,
I walked inside my vision.
But I came down from the cross,
for I fear heights
and I do not preach resurrection.
I changed nothing but my rhythm
so I could hear my heart clearly.
The epic poets have their eagles;
I have the Ring of the Dove,
a forgotten star above the roofs,
a winding street that leads
to the harbor of Acre—
no more and no less.

I want to greet the morning
where I left myself a happy child.
I was not a lucky child then,
but distance, like the finest blacksmith,
can hammer my worthless iron into a moon.

“Do you know me?”
I asked the shadow by the wall.
A girl dressed in fire turned around:
“Are you speaking to me?”
“I am speaking to my double, the ghost.”
She muttered, “Another Majnun of Layla
visiting the ruins,” and went back
to her shop at the far end of the old market.

Here we once lived. Two palm trees
carried some letters from poets
toward the sea. We have not grown
very much, my other self.
The seascape, the wall that defends
our losses, the scent of incense,
all say: We are still here,
even if time has separated from place.
Perhaps we never parted.

"Do you know me?"
The child I had lost began to cry:
"We never parted. But we will never
meet again." He closed two small waves
around his arms and flew high.

I asked: Which of us is the exile?

I said to the jailer on the western shore:
"Are you the son of my old jailer?"
"Yes."
"Where is your father?"
"He died years ago. Keeping watch
had worn him down with boredom.
He passed his duty and his trade to me,
and ordered me to protect the city
from your song."

"How long have you watched me,
locking yourself inside me?"
"Since you wrote your first songs."
"But you were not yet born."
"I have my own time and my eternity.
I want to live to America's rhythm
and Jerusalem's wall."

"Be who you are. But I have left.
The one you see now is not me;
he is my ghost."
"Enough! Are you not the name
of the stone echo? Then you neither left
nor came back. You are still
inside this yellow cell. Leave me alone!"

“Am I still here? Am I free,
or imprisoned without knowing?
And is the sea behind the wall my sea?”
“You are a prisoner of yourself
and of longing. The one you see
is not me. I am my ghost.”

Then I said to myself: I am alive.
And I said: When two ghosts meet
in the desert, do they share the sand,
or fight over who will own the night?

The Penultimate Passage

The harbor clock went on working by itself.
No one cared about the dark of time.
The fishermen of the sea’s fruit
cast their nets and braided the waves.
The lovers were at the disco.
Dreamers stroked sleeping larks
and went on dreaming.

And I said: If I die, I shall wake.
I have enough of the past;
what I lack is tomorrow.
I will walk the old road
in my own footsteps, in the sea air.
No woman will see me beneath her balcony.
Memory has given me only what is useful
for a long journey.

The days once held enough tomorrow.
I was younger than my butterflies,
younger than two dimples:
“Take my sleep and hide me
inside the story and the tender evening.
Hide me beneath one of the two palm trees.
And teach me poetry.”

Perhaps I will learn to wander
through Homer’s country.
Perhaps I will add to the story
a description of Acre,
oldest among beautiful cities,
most beautiful among the old:
a little stone box in whose clay
the living and the dead move
like bees imprisoned in a hive.

They go on strike against flowers
and ask the sea for an emergency exit
whenever the siege tightens.

Teach me poetry.
Perhaps some daughter will need a song
for the beloved who is far away:
“Take me to you, even by force,
and place my dream in your hands.”
Then they go off together into the echo,
arm in arm, as though I had married
a wandering stag to a doe,
and opened the doors of the church
to doves.

Teach me poetry.
The woman who spun a woolen shirt
and waited at the door
has earned the right to speak
of distance and disappointment:
“The warrior has not returned,
and will not return.
You are not the one I waited for.”

As Christ walked upon the lake,
I walked inside my vision.
But I came down from the cross,
for I fear heights
and do not preach resurrection.
I changed only my rhythm
so I could hear my heart more clearly.
The epic poets have their eagles;
I have the Ring of the Dove,
a forgotten star above the roofs,
and a street that leads to the harbor.

This sea is mine.
This damp air is mine.
This pavement, my footprints on it,
and my spilled seed, are mine. The old bus station is mine.
My ghost and its companion are mine.
The copper vessel and the Throne Verse,
the key, the door, the guards,
the ringing bells—all mine.
The horseshoe that flew over the walls
is mine. What once was mine is mine.
The scrap of paper torn from the Gospel
is mine. The salt left by tears

upon the wall of the house is mine.

And my name—if I pronounce it wrong,
the five letters from which it is made
are mine:

Mīm: the lover, the orphan,
the one who completes what has passed.
Ḥā’: the garden and the beloved,
two confusions, two regrets.
Mīm: the adventurer, the one prepared
for his promised death in exile,
sick with longing for what he desires.
Wāw: farewell, the middle rose,
loyalty to birth wherever it appears,
and the promise of parents.
Dāl: the signpost, the road, a tear
for a vanished home,
and a sparrow that spoils me
and draws my blood.

This name is mine,
and my friends’, wherever they may be.
My temporary body is mine,
whether present or absent.
Two meters of earth will be enough for now.
One meter and seventy-five centimeters
are mine. The rest is for wildflowers
in their disorder of colors,
drinking me slowly.

What was mine is mine: my yesterday,
and what will be mine, my distant tomorrow,
the return of my wandering soul.
As though nothing had happened.
As though nothing at all had happened:
a slight wound on the arm
of an absurd present.
History laughs at its victims
and at its heroes, glances their way,
and walks on.

This sea is mine.
This damp air is mine.
My name is mine—even if I mispronounce it
upon the coffin.

But I, filled now
with every reason to depart,
am not my own.
I am not my own.
I am not my own...